



BRIEFING PAPER

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May 2021 local elections

By Philip Brien

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Summary

143 councils in England held local elections on 6 May 2021, along with some that held by-elections to fill seats that had fallen vacant. This included councils that were due to hold elections this year anyway, and also those where elections had been scheduled for 2020 and postponed due to the Covid-19 pandemic.

4,732 councillors were elected across England – including by-elections, the total was 4,995, covering 4,117 wards and electoral districts.

Five local mayors were also elected, and there were three local referendums about the way councils were governed.

Council results by party

In the 143 councils in England that held local elections, the results by party were as follows:

- The **Conservatives** ended up in control of 63 of these councils, a **net gain of 11** compared with the previous scheduled election for each council. The party lost control of three councils (to no overall control), held 49, and gained 14 (three from Labour and 11 that were previously in no overall control).
- The **Labour** Party won 44 councils, a **net loss of 10**. Of the 10 councils they lost, three went to the Conservatives and seven to no overall control. They did not gain any councils.
- The **Liberal Democrats** won seven councils, a **net gain of one**. They lost no councils, held six, and gained one (from no overall control).
- 29 councils were in **no overall control, down by two** overall. There were 12 councils where a party gained enough seats to take control, and another 10 where a party that did have a majority lost it but no other party had enough seats to take over.
- Three councils changed from one party's control to another: Amber Valley, Harlow and Southampton all went from Labour to Conservative control.

Councillors by party

Adding up the councillors across all of these councils, the totals for each party were as follows:

- The **Conservatives** won 2,345 seats, 50% of those up for election. This was a **net gain of 234** compared with the results of the previous scheduled election for each council.
- The **Labour** Party won 1,345 seats, 28% of those up for election, giving a **net loss of 326**.
- The **Liberal Democrats** won 588 seats, 12% of those up for election, giving a **net gain of eight**.
- The **Green Party** won 151 seats, 3% of those up for election, giving a **net gain of 88**.

4 May 2021 local elections

- Other parties and independent candidates won 303 seats, 6% of those up for election.

The proportion of seats won by each party in councils holding only by-elections was fairly similar. Including these as well, the **Conservatives** won 2,500 seats, **Labour** won 1,407, the **Liberal Democrats** won 607, the **Green Party** won 157, and other parties and independents won 335.¹

¹ Library calculations using data from [Democracy Club candidates database](#), retrieved 11 May 2020

1. Local elections in England

England is divided into administrative areas governed by local authorities, which are either:

- Single tier authorities (unitary councils, metropolitan borough councils, and London borough councils); or
- Two-tier authorities, with county councils covering multiple lower-tier district councils.

On 6 May 2021, 143 councils in England held elections: 24 county councils, 28 unitary authorities, 35 metropolitan boroughs, and 62 shire districts. A number of other councils also held by-elections to fill seats that had fallen vacant (there were many more of these than usual because by-elections have been postponed during the Covid-19 pandemic).

In total, 4,995 council seats were up for election, covering 4,117 wards or electoral districts,² including four seats where the election was not contested because only one candidate stood.³

Some of these elections were due to take place in 2020, but were postponed due to the coronavirus outbreak. More information on the process by which the elections were postponed and measures taken to allow the elections to go ahead in 2021 is in our Briefing Paper, [Coronavirus: elections](#).

1.1 Electoral cycles

Local council members are elected for 4-year terms using the first past the post system. There are a variety of electoral cycles, so not all councillors are elected at the same time: some authorities elect their entire council at once, while others elect a proportion of members each year.

There are three methods of holding elections to local councils:

- **Whole:** All councillors are elected once every four years, in whole council elections.
- **Thirds:** Councillors are elected for four-year terms by thirds; that is, at each election, a third of the councillors are elected. Elections are held every year except in years when there are county council elections in the rest of England.
- **Halves:** Councillors are elected for four-year terms by halves; that is, at each election, half the councillors are elected. Elections are held every two years.

² Library calculation, based on data from the [Democracy Club candidates database](#). These figures were corrected on 16 June 2021 after discussion with Democracy Club. The new figure does not include five seats where the election was postponed; if we also subtract the four candidates elected unopposed (see next footnote), 4,991 candidates were elected on 6 May across 4,113 wards or districts.

³ Three independent candidates were elected unopposed in the Isles of Scilly (in the St Agnes, St Martin's, and Tresco wards), and one Conservative candidate was elected unopposed in Shropshire's Albrighton ward.

Local election cycles in England: a rough guide							
	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Unitary Councils							
Metropolitan							
London Boroughs							
District Councils							
County Councils							

Shaded areas indicate when elections are scheduled.

As this chart shows, many metropolitan and shire district councils were supposed to have elections in 2020 rather than this year. However, due to the Covid-19 pandemic, these elections were postponed.⁴ This means that there were, broadly, three sets of seats up for election this year:

- Those initially up for election in 2020 – these seats were last contested in 2016;
- Those which had been scheduled to take place this year anyway – these were last contested in 2017;
- Those which, for one reason or another, fall outside the normal schedule. These include local by-elections, where council seats have become vacant during a councillor's term, and councils where either their overall structure or their boundaries have changed. In these cases, all councils (even those normally using a different method for holding elections) must hold elections for the entire council.

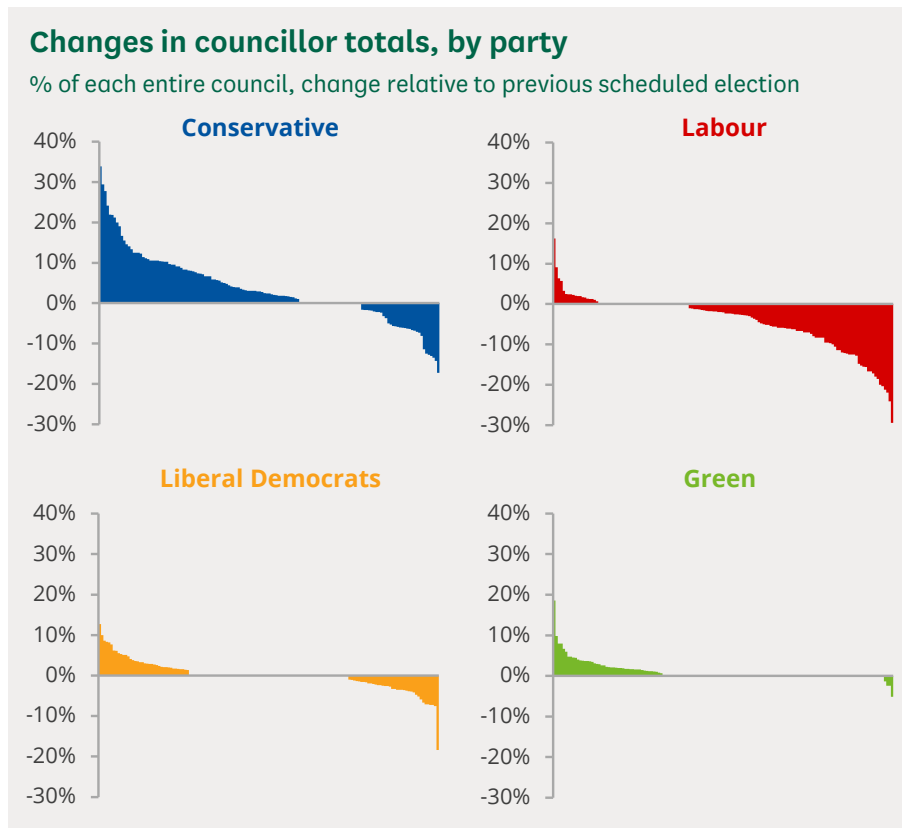
Most of the data presented in this briefing paper covers only the councils where elections were scheduled for 2020 and 2021 – that is, except where otherwise noted, the summary statistics do not include councils which only held by-elections this year.⁵

⁴ For further details, see the Library's Insight post [Coronavirus: FAQs on postponed elections](#), published 6 May 2020

⁵ Results from by-elections are included in summary statistics if that by-election took place alongside a scheduled election for the council.

2. Results by party

The numbers of councillors gained and lost by the Conservatives, Labour, the Liberal Democrats and the Green Party is shown in the chart below.



Source: Library calculations based on BBC data

Each party's chart here shows the change in the number of councillors representing that party for each of the 143 councils that held scheduled elections, relative to the previous scheduled election. The size of each change is shown as a proportion of the whole council, so that councils of different sizes can be meaningfully compared.

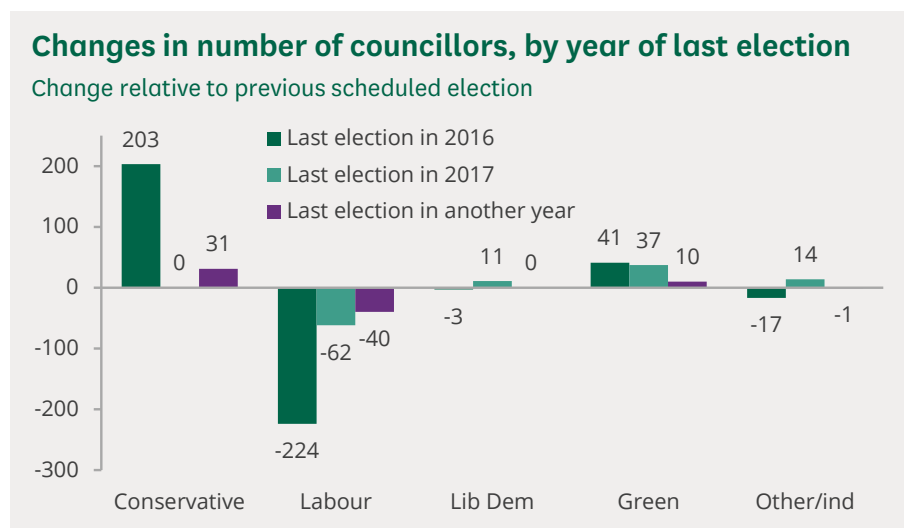
This shows that the **Conservatives** gained seats in the majority of councils – for the most part, the net gain was less than 10% of the whole council, but there were some outliers. The biggest proportional change in the Conservatives' favour was in Rotherham, where they gained 20 councillors (34% of the council); Labour's majority was reduced from 29 to 5. However, they did also lose seats in 33 councils – their largest loss was in Surrey, where they lost 14 councillors (17% of the council) and saw their majority cut from 41 to 13.

By contrast, **Labour** lost councillors in the majority of councils, with its heaviest proportional loss in Nuneaton & Bedworth (where it lost 10 councillors, 29% of the council, and the Conservatives gained control). It did still make some gains in 19 councils, with the largest gain coming in Worthing (where it gained six councillors, 16% of the council, and the Conservative majority fell from 11 to 1).

The **Liberal Democrats** generally balanced their gains and losses across England in proportional terms, and rarely saw any major shifts – there were only three councils where they gained or lost at least 10% of the council. Their biggest proportional gain was in Oxfordshire, where they gained eight councillors (13% of the council); their third largest was in St Albans, where they gained five councillors (9%) and took control of the council. Their largest loss by some way was in Cornwall, where they lost 16 councillors (18% of the council) and the Conservatives gained control of the council (it had previously been under no overall control).

The changes in councillors seen by the **Green Party** were typically not very large, but their gains generally outweighed their losses. Their largest gain was in Bristol, where they gained 13 councillors (19% of the council), resulting in Labour losing control of the council. Their largest loss was in Rochford, where they lost two of their three councillors (5% of the council).

The year in which councils had their previous scheduled election made a difference to the gains and losses for each party.



Source: Library calculations based on BBC data

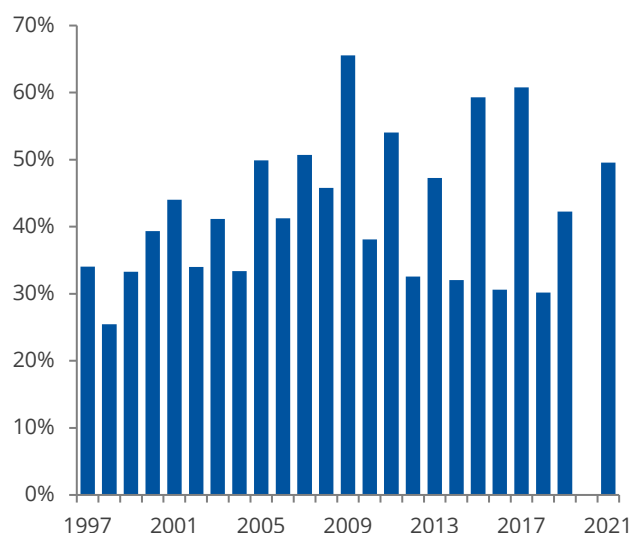
The Conservative gains and Labour losses in these elections were mostly in councils where the previous set of elections had taken place in 2016. These elections included metropolitan and district councils but not county councils (which last had elections in 2017); the difference in the political makeup of these types of councils may help to explain the differences in the changes in councillors.

The charts and tables on the following pages summarise each party's performance and give some context from previous years.

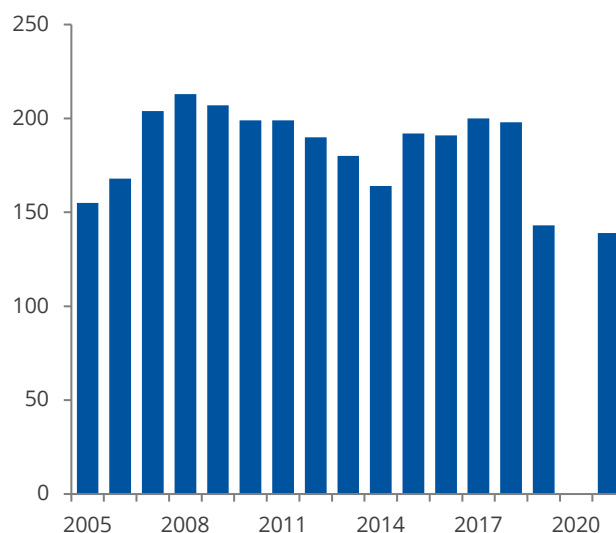
Conservative

The Conservatives won 50% of the seats up for election on 6 May 2021, up from 42% in 2019. The overall number of councils controlled by the Conservatives increased by 13 compared to immediately before the election. Although at 139, the total is the lowest in more than 15 years, this is partly due to local authority restructures meaning that there are fewer councils overall.

Percent of seats up for election won^a



Councils controlled^b



Summary of Conservative local election results

Election year	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021
Seats won	5,113	786	1,117	1,366	5,540	851	1,440	1,332	3,559	2,345
Unitary Councils	851	105	183	115	941	138	231	108	698	648
Metropolitan	151	110		128	162	114	7	175	119	226
London Boroughs				612				511		
District Councils	4111	571		511	4437	599		538	2742	534
County Councils			934				1202			937
% of seats up for election won ^a	54%	33%	47%	32%	59%	31%	61%	30%	42%	50%
Councils controlled^b	199	190	180	164	192	191	200	198	143	139
Unitary Councils	23	20	20	18	19	21	22	23	16	22
Metropolitan	3	2	2	2	2	2	2	1	2	3
London Boroughs	11	11	11	9	9	9	9	7	7	7
District Councils	136	131	131	119	146	143	143	143	95	86
County Councils	26	26	16	16	16	16	24	24	23	21
Net change in council control ^c	1	-10	-10	-13	28	-1	9	-2	-49	13

Notes and sources

a. All figures England only. Shows seats won by stated party as a percentage of total seats up for election. Note not all parties field candidates in all seats.

b. Council control immediately following elections of stated year.

c. Net change compared to control immediately prior to election; figures not comparable with year-on-year changes to total number of councils controlled by party.

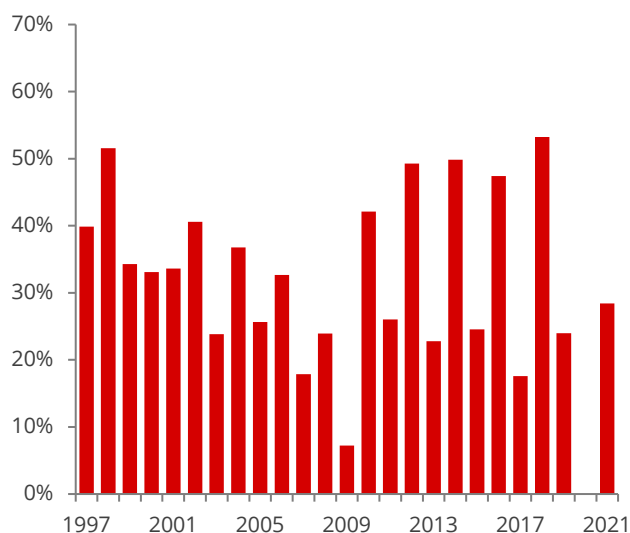
d. Figures for councils controlled and net change in councils controlled refer to those controlled by an absolute majority; minority controlled councils are excluded.

Sources: 1997 - 2017 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Elections Handbooks; 2018 and 2019 data collated by House of Commons Library; Rallings and Thrasher, "Voters turned their backs on the main two parties", Local Government Chronicle, 7 May 2019, and "Brexit is changing voting patterns", Local Government Chronicle, 14 May 2021; BBC

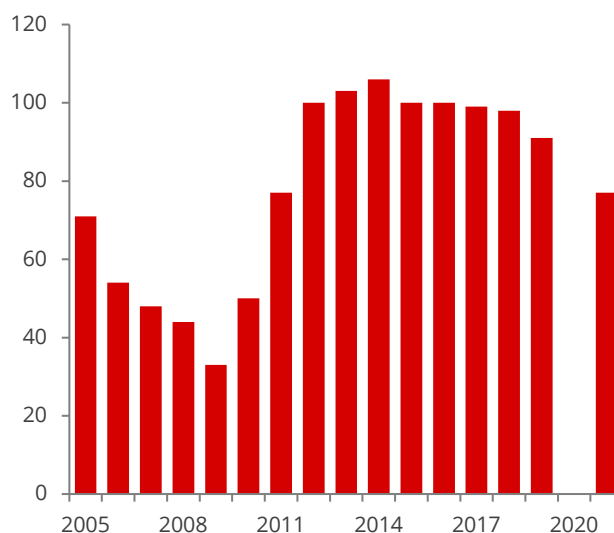
Labour

Labour won 28% of the seats up for election on 6 May 2021, up by four percentage points on the proportion it won in 2019. The overall number of councils controlled by Labour decreased by eight compared to 2019; it is now at its lowest level since 2011. The party has now not made a net gain in councils controlled in scheduled local elections since 2014.

Percent of seats up for election won^a



Councils controlled^b



Summary of Labour local election results

Election year	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021
Seats won	2,461	1,189	538	2,124	2,292	1,319	417	2,355	2,020	1,345
Unitary Councils	707	203	158	191	673	233	115	187	589	333
Metropolitan	594	604		565	634	664	43	723	472	571
London Boroughs				1060				1125		
District Councils	1160	382		308	985	422		320	959	269
County Councils			380				259			172
% of seats up for election won ^a	26%	49%	23%	50%	25%	47%	18%	53%	24%	28%
Councils controlled^b	77	100	103	106	100	100	99	98	91	77
Unitary Councils	17	23	23	21	18	19	20	20	15	11
Metropolitan	24	29	29	30	30	29	29	30	30	28
London Boroughs	17	17	17	20	20	21	21	21	21	21
District Councils	19	31	32	33	30	30	29	27	25	17
County Councils	0	0	2	2	2	1	0	0	0	0
Net change in council control ^c	26	24	2	4	-6	0	-1	0	-6	-8

Notes and sources

a. All figures England only. Shows seats won by stated party as a percentage of total seats up for election. Note not all parties field candidates in all seats.

b. Council control immediately following elections of stated year.

c. Net change compared to control immediately prior to election; figures not comparable with year-on-year changes to total number of councils controlled by party.

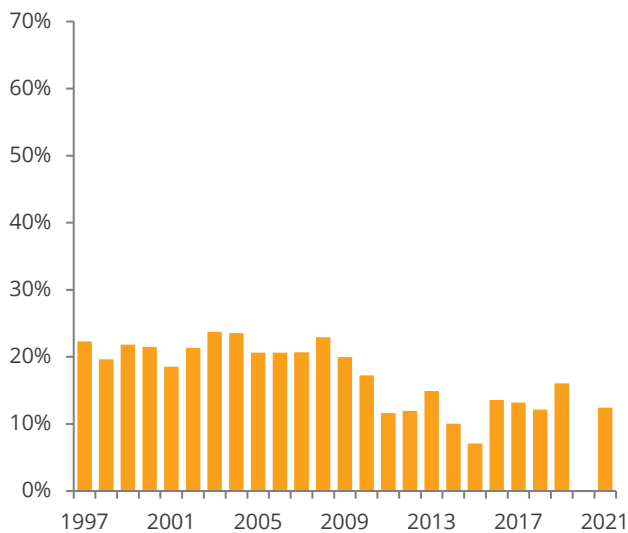
d. Figures for councils controlled and net change in councils controlled refer to those controlled by an absolute majority; minority controlled councils are excluded.

Sources: 1997 - 2017 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Elections Handbooks; 2018 and 2019 data collated by House of Commons Library; Rallings and Thrasher, "Voters turned their backs on the main two parties", Local Government Chronicle, 7 May 2019, and "Brexit is changing voting patterns", Local Government Chronicle, 14 May 2021; BBC

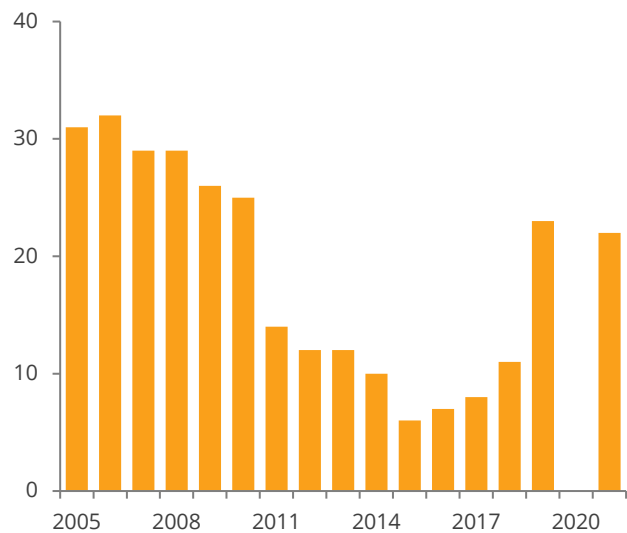
Liberal Democrat

The Liberal Democrats won 12% of all seats up for election, four percentage points lower than the proportion won in 2019, and about the same proportion they won in 2018. Their total of councils controlled was 22, one lower than in 2019. This is still well above where they have been in some recent years, but not as high as in 2006, when they controlled 32 councils.

Percent of seats up for election won^a



Councils controlled^b



Summary of Liberal Democrat local election results

Election year	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021
Seats won	1,099	288	352	429	661	377	313	537	1,351	588
Unitary Councils	216	40	101	45	123	54	88	48	287	146
Metropolitan	56	72		66	40	88	0	83	80	70
London Boroughs				116				152		
District Councils	827	176		202	498	235		254	984	177
County Councils			251				225			195
% of seats up for election won ^a	12%	12%	15%	10%	7%	14%	13%	12%	16%	12%
Councils controlled^b	14	12	12	10	6	7	8	11	23	22
Unitary Councils	1	1	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	1
Metropolitan	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
London Boroughs	2	2	2	1	1	1	1	3	3	3
District Councils	11	9	9	9	5	6	7	8	19	18
County Councils	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Net change in council control ^c	-10	1	0	-2	-4	1	0	4	12	1

Notes and sources

a. All figures England only. Shows seats won by stated party as a percentage of total seats up for election. Note not all parties field candidates in all seats.

b. Council control immediately following elections of stated year.

c. Net change compared to control immediately prior to election; figures not comparable with year-on-year changes to total number of councils controlled by party.

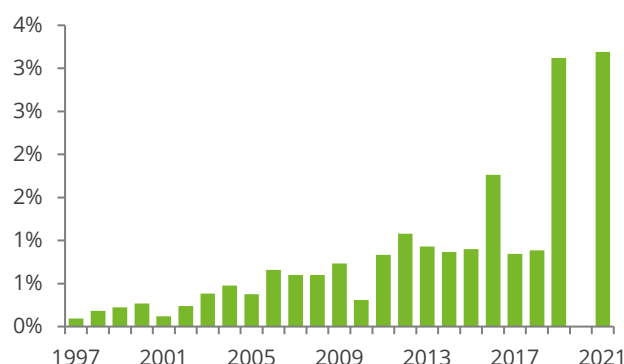
d. Figures for councils controlled and net change in councils controlled refer to those controlled by an absolute majority; minority controlled councils are excluded.

Sources: 1997 - 2017 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Elections Handbooks; 2018 and 2019 data collated by House of Commons Library; Rallings and Thrasher, "Voters turned their backs on the main two parties", Local Government Chronicle, 7 May 2019, and "Brexit is changing voting patterns", Local Government Chronicle, 14 May 2021; BBC

Green

The Green Party won 151 seats at the local elections on 6 May 2021, around 3% of all seats up for election. This is the highest proportion of seats the Green Party has won in more than twenty years. The Green Party does not currently control any councils in Great Britain.

Percent of seats up for election won^a

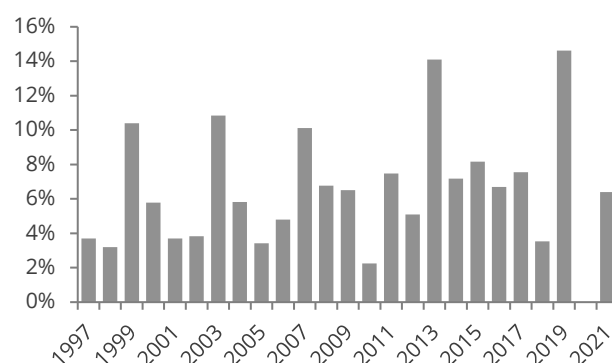


Election year	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021
Seats won	79	26	22	37	84	49	20	39	263	151
Unitary Councils	30	1	3	5	30	15	2	2	51	42
Metropolitan	8	10		12	7	12	0	18	24	27
London Boroughs				4				11		
District Councils	41	15		16	47	22		8	188	39
County Councils			19				18			43
% of seats up for election won ^a	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	2%	1%	1%	3%	3%

Other parties and independents

Other parties and independent candidates won 303 seats in the local elections on 6 May 2021, around 6% of the seats up for election. The highest proportion of seats won by other parties and independents was 15% in 2019. No parties other than the Conservatives, Labour and the Liberal Democrats currently control any councils in England.

Percent of seats up for election won^a



Election year	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021
Seats won	708	123	333	306	763	186	179	156	1,232	303
Unitary Councils	132	20	106	48	145	28	91	14	259	115
Metropolitan	15	26		54	17	43	5	25	39	28
London Boroughs				59				34		
District Councils	561	77		145	601	115		77	934	78
County Councils			227				83			82
% of seats up for election won ^a	7%	5%	14%	7%	8%	7%	8%	4%	15%	6%

Notes and sources

a. All figures England only. Shows seats won by stated party as a percentage of total seats up for election. Note not all parties field candidates in all seats.

Sources: 1997 - 2017 data from Rallings & Thrasher Local Elections Handbooks; 2018 and 2019 data collated by House of Commons Library; Rallings and Thrasher, "Voters turned their backs on the main two parties", Local Government Chronicle, 7 May 2019, and "Brexit is changing voting patterns", Local Government Chronicle, 14 May 2021; BBC

3. Post-election composition in England

The table below summarises council composition and control for all local authorities in England immediately following the local elections held on 6 May 2021. This includes councils where elections were not held.

English post-election council composition: May 2021					
	CON	LAB	LD	OTH	NOC
Councillors					
Number					
London boroughs	511	1,105	156	61	-
Counties	1,064	206	227	138	-
Metropolitan boroughs	476	1,532	209	179	-
Shire districts	3,642	1,313	1,311	1,344	-
Unitary authorities	1,435	986	459	506	-
England	7,128	5,142	2,362	2,228	-
Percent					
London boroughs	28%	60%	9%	3%	-
Counties	65%	13%	14%	8%	-
Metropolitan boroughs	20%	64%	9%	7%	-
Shire districts	48%	17%	17%	18%	-
Unitary authorities	42%	29%	14%	15%	-
England	42%	30%	14%	13%	-
Councils controlled					
Number					
London boroughs	7	21	3	0	1
Counties	21	0	0	0	3
Metropolitan boroughs	3	28	0	0	5
Shire districts	86	17	18	5	55
Unitary authorities	22	11	1	0	24
England	139	77	22	5	88
Percent					
London boroughs	22%	66%	9%	0%	3%
Counties	88%	0%	0%	0%	13%
Metropolitan boroughs	8%	78%	0%	0%	14%
Shire districts	48%	9%	10%	3%	30%
Unitary authorities	38%	19%	2%	0%	41%
England	42%	23%	7%	2%	27%

Source: Rallings and Thrasher, "[Brexit is changing voting patterns](#)", Local Government Chronicle, 14 May 2021

The **Conservatives** hold the greatest share of seats and councils in England (42% for both). **Labour** are second with 30% of councillors and 23% of councils controlled. The **Liberal Democrats** control 7% of councils, while 27% of councils have no overall control, and five councils are controlled by an 'other' party.

The following table looks at council composition and control for all local authorities in England immediately following elections by year (generally

held on the first Thursday of May). As above, this includes those where elections were not held.

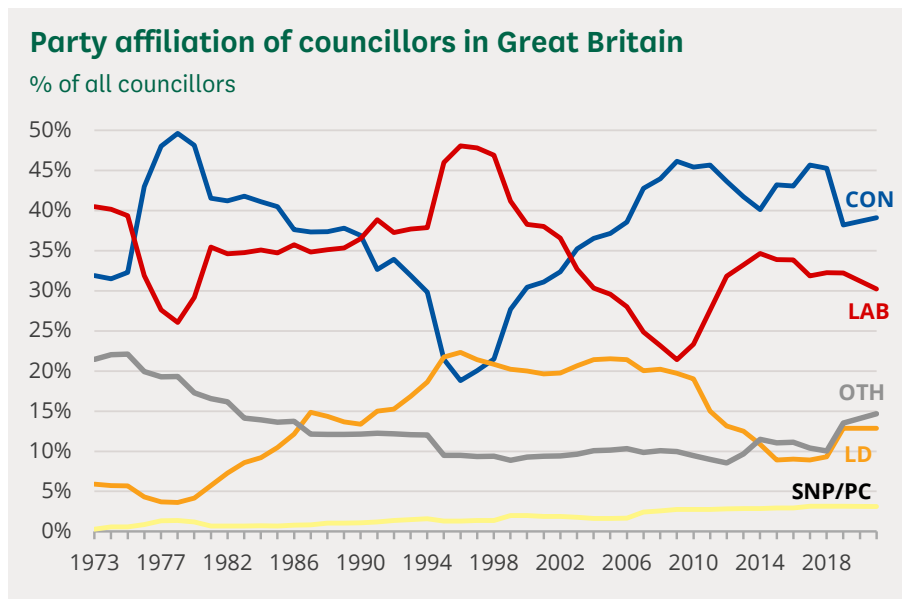
English council control immediately after local elections										
	Number					Percent				
	CON	LAB	LD	OTH	NOC	CON	LAB	LD	OTH	NOC
2005	155	71	31	7	122	40%	18%	8%	2%	32%
2006	168	54	32	5	127	44%	14%	8%	1%	33%
2007	204	48	29	5	100	53%	12%	8%	1%	26%
2008	213	44	29	5	95	55%	11%	8%	1%	25%
2009	207	33	26	4	81	59%	9%	7%	1%	23%
2010	199	50	25	4	73	57%	14%	7%	1%	21%
2011	199	77	14	1	60	57%	22%	4%	0%	17%
2012	190	100	12	1	48	54%	28%	3%	0%	14%
2013	180	103	12	1	55	51%	29%	3%	0%	16%
2014	164	106	10	1	70	47%	30%	3%	0%	20%
2015	192	100	6	2	51	55%	28%	2%	1%	15%
2016	191	100	7	1	52	54%	28%	2%	0%	15%
2017	200	99	8	2	42	57%	28%	2%	1%	12%
2018	198	98	11	1	43	56%	28%	3%	0%	12%
2019	143	91	23	5	79	42%	27%	7%	1%	23%
2020	(no local elections in this year because of the Covid-19 pandemic)									
2021	139	77	22	5	88	41%	23%	7%	2%	27%

Sources: Rallings and Thrasher, "[Voters turned their backs on the main two parties](#)", Local Government Chronicle, 9 May 2019, and "[Brexiteer is changing voting patterns](#)", Local Government Chronicle, 14 May 2021; House of Commons Library

The **Conservatives** control four fewer councils compared with 2019 and **Labour** control 14 fewer. The **Liberal Democrats** control 22 councils, down by one on 2019. This is still lower than any time in the decade before 2010. Their highest return in this period came in 2006, when they controlled 32 councils, only 22 fewer than Labour at the time. The proportion of councils that have no overall control has increased again, and is now more than double the proportion in 2018, up from 12% in 2018 to 27% in 2021.

In the recent past, the **Conservatives** typically controlled approximately twice as many councils as **Labour** (for example, 56% vs. 28% in 2018). This was no longer the case in 2019 (42% vs. 27%), although since then the Conservatives have made some gains back. Their best result in the past decade was in 2009 when they controlled 59% of councils, compared with **Labour's** 9%.

The chart below shows the number of councillors by party in Great Britain from 1973 to 2021. Following the elections in May 2021, the **Conservatives** have 7,562 (39% of all) councillors in Great Britain, **Labour** have 5,849 (30%), the **Liberal Democrats** 2,487 (13%), and **Plaid Cymru** and the **Scottish National Party** combined have 605 (3%). There are a further 2,838 (15%) councillors in Great Britain who are either independents or affiliated with other parties. This is up from 2,655 (14%) in 2019.



Sources: Rallings and Thrasher, "[Voters turned their backs on the main two parties](#)", Local Government Chronicle, 9 May 2019, and "[Brexit is changing voting patterns](#)", Local Government Chronicle, 14 May 2021; House of Commons Library

4. Mayoral elections in England

Five local authorities – Bristol, Doncaster, Liverpool, North Tyneside and Salford – elected local mayors this year. Local mayors are effectively the leaders of their councils, and are distinct from metro-mayors, who lead combined authorities. For results in this year's metro-mayor elections, see our separate briefing paper, which will be published as part of our [overall series on the May 2021 elections](#).

Mayoral elections are held using the Supplementary Vote system, where voters indicate their first and second preference. If no candidate achieves 50% of first preference votes, only the two candidates with the highest numbers of votes are retained. The second preference votes for these candidates recorded on the ballot papers of the eliminated candidates are counted and the candidate with the highest number of total votes is elected.

Labour candidates won all five local mayoral contests. Labour had also won all five previously (although its previous winner in Liverpool wasn't still in place by the time of the election – Joe Anderson, who won the Liverpool mayoralty as a Labour candidate in 2016, stepped down in December 2020 and was temporarily replaced by deputy mayor Wendy Simon).⁶

In three of the contests, second preference votes were needed to determine the winner, as no candidate received more than 50% of first preference votes.

Three of the winning candidates were women (two of them were re-elected), and two were from a minority ethnic background (one was re-elected). Joanne Anderson was elected in Liverpool, becoming the first black woman to lead a major UK city.⁷

⁶ BBC News, [Liverpool mayor Joe Anderson steps aside amid bribery probe](#), 10 December 2020

⁷ BBC News, [Elections results 2021: Joanne Anderson elected Liverpool city mayor](#), 8 May 2021

Council mayoral election results

		First preference		Second preference		Total vote	
		Number	%	Number	%	Number	%
Bristol						LAB hold	
Marvin Rees	LAB	50,510	36.3%	8,766	48.4%	59,276	56.5%
Sandy Hore-Ruthven	GRN	36,331	26.1%	9,332	51.6%	45,663	43.5%
Alastair Watson	CON	25,816	18.6%				
Caroline Gooch	LD	15,517	11.2%				
Sean Donnelly	IND	4,956	3.6%				
Tom Baldwin	OTH	3,194	2.3%				
John Langley	IND	1,528	1.1%				
Robert Clarke	OTH	806	0.6%				
Oska Shaw	IND	389	0.3%				
Electorate		343,163					
Turnout		40.5%					
Doncaster						LAB hold	
Ros Jones	LAB	27,669	43.8%	3,563	54.0%	31,232	59.8%
James Hart	CON	17,980	28.5%	3,039	46.0%	21,019	40.2%
Frank Calladine	IND	5,166	8.2%				
Andy Budden	OTH	4,073	6.4%				
Joan Briggs	IND	3,904	6.2%				
Warren Draper	GRN	3,370	5.3%				
Surjit Duhre	OTH	1,012	1.6%				
Electorate		227,702					
Turnout		27.7%					
Liverpool						LAB hold	
Joanne Anderson	LAB	38,958	38.5%	7,535	42.9%	46,493	59.2%
Stephen Yip	IND	22,047	21.8%	10,032	57.1%	32,079	40.8%
Richard Kemp	LD	17,166	17.0%				
Tom Crone	GRN	8,768	8.7%				
Steve Radford	OTH	7,135	7.1%				
Katie Burgess	CON	4,187	4.1%				
Roger Bannister	OTH	2,912	2.9%				
Electorate		336,382					
Turnout		30.1%					
North Tyneside						LAB hold	
Norma Redfearn	LAB	33,119	53.4%	A candidate received more than 50% of the valid first preference vote and was therefore elected without second preference votes being counted.			
Steven Robinson	CON	19,366	31.2%				
Penny Remfry	GRN	4,278	6.9%				
John Appleby	LD	3,549	5.7%				
Jack Thomson	OTH	1,753	2.8%				
Electorate		157,501					
Turnout		39.4%					
Salford						LAB hold	
Paul Dennett	LAB	30,892	59.0%	A candidate received more than 50% of the valid first preference vote and was therefore elected without second preference votes being counted.			
Arnie Saunders	CON	12,234	23.4%				
Wendy Olsen	GRN	4,585	8.8%				
Stephen Ord	IND	1,890	3.6%				
Jake Overend	LD	1,716	3.3%				
Stuart Cremins	IND	1,036	2.0%				
Electorate		186,058					
Turnout		28.1%					

Source: Results published online or provided by local authorities

5. Local referendums

Local authorities are able to hold referendums on a number of different subjects (see our briefing paper [Local government: polls and referendums](#) for more details). Councils may hold a referendum when making these three decisions:

- Whether to raise council tax levels past the Government's threshold (the thresholds for this year are detailed in our briefing paper [Council tax: local referendums](#));
- Whether the council should change its governance model between three different systems;
- Whether to accept neighbourhood plans (see our briefing paper [Neighbourhood planning](#)).

There were three referendums on governance models alongside this year's elections:

- Residents in **Tower Hamlets** and **Newham** both chose to retain their current directly-elected mayors rather than switching to a different system;
- Residents in **Sheffield** backed a proposal to stop using their current system of a leader elected by councillors, replacing it with a system of committees made up of councillors. The new system will be brought in from May 2022.⁸

Croydon Borough Council will hold a similar referendum, deciding whether to continue with their current leader-and-cabinet model or move to a directly elected mayor, on 7 October 2021.⁹

⁸ SheffNews, [Sheffield vote for a committee system](#), 10 May 2021

⁹ Croydon Borough Council, [Mayoral referendum to be held in October](#), 9 February 2021

Governance referendum results

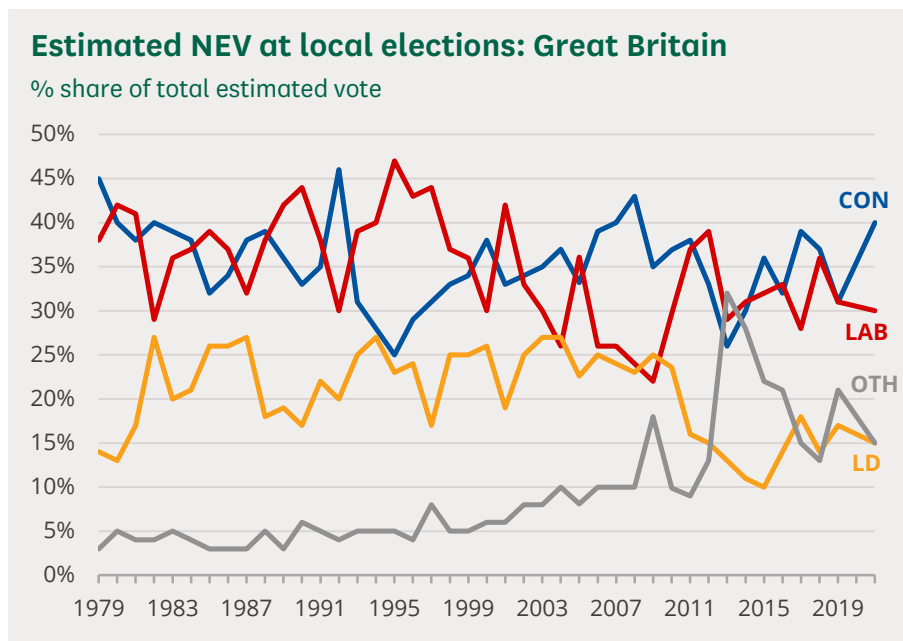
	Votes	%
Tower Hamlets		
Keep directly elected Mayor	63,029	77.8%
Change to leader and cabinet model	17,951	22.2%
Spoilt ballots	3,444	
Turnout	41.8%	
Newham		
Keep directly elected Mayor	45,960	55.8%
Change to committee model	36,424	44.2%
Spoilt ballots	2,703	
Turnout	37.7%	
Sheffield		
Keep leader and cabinet model	48,727	35.2%
Change to committee model	89,670	64.8%
Spoilt ballots	1,789	
Turnout	n/a*	

* Sheffield also had scheduled local elections, so the turnout just for the referendum was not reported

Source: Results published online or provided by local authorities

6. National share of the vote

Opinion polling aside, it is difficult to get an overview of how much support political parties attract across Great Britain in the years between general elections, because local elections are not held in all local authorities at the same time. Academics Colin Rallings and Michael Thrasher overcome this problem by using the results of local elections to estimate how the major parties would have fared had these elections taken place throughout Great Britain. Rallings and Thrasher's National Equivalent share of the vote (NEV) is a widely used estimate of where the parties stand in the years between general elections.



The table below shows that the **Conservatives** had an estimated vote share of 40%, up nine points from 31% in 2019. **Labour**'s share was 30%, down by one point from 31% in 2019. The **Liberal Democrats'** NEV decreased from 17% in 2019 to 15%.

The 'others' category's NEV decreased from 21% to 15%, falling back from an increase in 2019. 'Others' achieved a similar proportion of the NEV in 2017 (15%) and 2018 (13%), and their NEV had been higher before then, peaking at 32% in 2013. This is because the 'others' category includes UKIP; in 2013, UKIP attracted 22% of the NEV, with the remaining 10% shared by independents and other parties. Since then, UKIP's share has fallen; it was 4% in 2019, and not estimated in 2021.

Estimated NEV at local elections: Great Britain

	CON	LAB	LD	OTHERS	of which UKIP
1979	45%	38%	14%	3%	
1980	40%	42%	13%	5%	
1981	38%	41%	17%	4%	
1982	40%	29%	27%	4%	
1983	39%	36%	20%	5%	
1984	38%	37%	21%	4%	
1985	32%	39%	26%	3%	
1986	34%	37%	26%	3%	
1987	38%	32%	27%	3%	
1988	39%	38%	18%	5%	
1989	36%	42%	19%	3%	
1990	33%	44%	17%	6%	
1991	35%	38%	22%	5%	
1992	46%	30%	20%	4%	
1993	31%	39%	25%	5%	
1994	28%	40%	27%	5%	
1995	25%	47%	23%	5%	
1996	29%	43%	24%	4%	
1997	31%	44%	17%	8%	
1998	33%	37%	25%	5%	
1999	34%	36%	25%	5%	
2000	38%	30%	26%	6%	
2001	33%	42%	19%	6%	
2002	34%	33%	25%	8%	
2003	35%	30%	27%	8%	
2004	37%	26%	27%	10%	
2005	33%	36%	23%	8%	
2006	39%	26%	25%	10%	
2007	40%	26%	24%	10%	
2008	43%	24%	23%	10%	
2009	35%	22%	25%	18%	
2010	37%	30%	24%	10%	
2011	38%	37%	16%	9%	
2012	33%	39%	15%	13%	
2013	26%	29%	13%	32%	22%
2014	30%	31%	11%	28%	18%
2015	36%	32%	10%	22%	12%
2016	32%	33%	14%	21%	12%
2017	39%	28%	18%	15%	4%
2018	37%	36%	14%	13%	
2019	31%	31%	17%	21%	4%
2020	(no local elections in this year because of the Covid-19 pandemic)				
2021	40%	30%	15%	15%	

Notes: Years with grey shading indicate that a General Election was held on the same day and in these years General Election vote share is shown. UKIP vote share calculated was between 2013 and 2017 and again in 2019. At the 2019 General Election the GB vote share was 44.7% for the Conservatives, 32.9% Labour, 11.8% Liberal Democrats, and 10.5% for other parties/independents.

Sources: Rallings and Thrasher, British Electoral Facts 1832-2012; Rallings and Thrasher, Local Elections Handbook, various years; Rallings and Thrasher, "Voters turned their backs on the main two parties", Local Government Chronicle, 9 May 2019; Rallings and Thrasher, "City victories are cold comfort for Labour", The Sunday Times, 9 May 2021

7. About the data

Local election results are not collated centrally by an official body. Academics Colin Rallings and Michael Thrasher have compiled [Local Elections Handbooks](#) for England each year since 1985. Historic data quoted in this briefing paper is derived, in most cases, from these handbooks; 2019 figures for net change in seats and councils controlled are derived from Rallings and Thrasher's May 2019 articles in [The Sunday Times](#) and [Local Government Chronicle](#). The 2021 figures are from their May 2021 articles in the same publications.¹⁰

The data on the 2021 elections in this briefing paper were mostly provided by the BBC, with some figures checked directly against council websites, and some derived from [Democracy Club](#)'s data.

Reported findings may in some cases differ from analysis available elsewhere, as a result of different definitions or reference points used. Local elections results can be analysed by looking at either:

- a. The total number of councils controlled and councillors a party has at a given time, usually immediately following elections. Chronological comparisons focus on the situation immediately after two or more elections (as in section 2 and the reference tables below); or
- b. The number of councils won/lost or seats won/lost at any given round of elections. This entails a comparison of the situation immediately before and immediately after these elections (as on the party pages).

It is not always possible to compare directly between data based on definitions 'A' and 'B' as they in effect monitor different things.

A party's number of councillors and number of councils controlled are subject to change between the yearly local elections (for example through defections and by-elections), meaning figures used to calculate net change at an election ('B') will not necessarily match with the totals monitored on an annual basis ('A').

Moreover, we record a party as in control of a council when they hold a majority of seats (i.e. more than 50%). Other organisations may report a party as in control of a council when they hold exactly 50% of seats, or when they hold fewer seats but have reached a governing agreement with another party.

In addition to these concerns, the Covid-19 pandemic has made comparisons difficult, because not all of the seats up for election this year were last contested at the same time (and a significant proportion are by-elections filling casual vacancies or are otherwise not comparable to any particular baseline).

¹⁰ Sunday Times, "[City victories are cold comfort for Labour](#)", 9 May 2021; Local Government Chronicle, "[Brexit is changing voting patterns](#)", 14 May 2021

England local elections 2021: Results

		Seats last contested	Council composition (post May 2021 elections)							Share of seats (%)					Total councillors compared with when seats last contested					
Authority			CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	Vacant	Total	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	
B	County councils																			
	Cambridgeshire	NOC	2017	28	9	20	0	4	61	46%	15%	33%	0%	7%	-8	2	5	0	1	
	Derbyshire	CON	2017	45	14	4	1	0	64	70%	22%	6%	2%	0%	9	-11	1	1	0	
	Devon	CON	2017	39	7	9	2	3	60	65%	12%	15%	3%	5%	-3	0	2	1	0	
	East Sussex	CON	2017	27	5	11	4	3	50	54%	10%	22%	8%	6%	-3	1	0	4	-2	
	Essex	CON	2017	52	5	8	1	9	75	69%	7%	11%	1%	12%	-4	-1	1	0	4	
	Gloucestershire	CON	2017	28	5	16	4	0	53	53%	9%	30%	8%	0%	-3	0	2	2	-1	
	Hampshire	CON	2017	56	3	17	0	2	78	72%	4%	22%	0%	3%	0	1	-2	0	1	
	Hertfordshire	CON	2017	46	7	23	1	1	78	59%	9%	29%	1%	1%	-5	-1	4	1	1	
	Kent	CON	2017	61	7	6	4	2	1	81	75%	9%	7%	5%	2%	-5	2	-1	3	1
	Lancashire	CON	2017	48	32	2	2	0	84	57%	38%	2%	2%	0%	2	2	-2	1	-3	
	Leicestershire	CON	2017	42	4	9	0	0	55	76%	7%	16%	0%	0%	6	-2	-4	0	0	
	Lincolnshire	CON	2017	54	4	3	0	9	70	77%	6%	4%	0%	13%	-4	-2	2	0	4	
	Norfolk	CON	2017	58	11	8	3	3	1	84	69%	13%	10%	4%	4%	3	-5	-3	3	2
	Nottinghamshire	CON	2017	37	15	1	0	13	66	56%	23%	2%	0%	20%	6	-8	0	0	2	
	Oxfordshire	NOC	2017	22	15	21	3	2	63	35%	24%	33%	5%	3%	-9	1	8	3	-3	
	Staffordshire	CON	2017	57	4	0	0	1	62	92%	6%	0%	0%	2%	6	-6	0	0	0	
	Suffolk	CON	2017	55	5	4	9	2	75	73%	7%	5%	12%	3%	3	-6	-1	6	-2	
	Surrey	CON	2017	47	2	14	2	16	81	58%	2%	17%	2%	20%	-14	1	5	1	7	
	Warwickshire	CON	2017	42	6	5	3	1	57	74%	11%	9%	5%	2%	6	-4	-2	1	-1	
	West Sussex	CON	2017	48	9	10	1	2	70	69%	13%	14%	1%	3%	-8	4	1	1	2	
Worcestershire	CON	2017	45	3	4	3	2	57	79%	5%	7%	5%	4%	5	-7	1	1	0		
Total county councils			937	172	195	43	75	2	1,424	66%	12%	14%	3%	5%	-20	-39	+17	+29	+13	

		Seats last contested	Council composition (post May 2021 elections)							Share of seats (%)					Total councillors compared with when seats last contested				
Authority			CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	Vacant	Total	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH
District councils																			
	Adur	CON	2016	19	7	0	1	2	29	66%	24%	0%	3%	7%	3	0	0	1	-4
	Amber Valley	CON	2016	28	16	0	1	0	45	62%	36%	0%	2%	0%	9	-9	0	0	0
	Basildon	CON	2016	22	12	0	0	8	42	52%	29%	0%	0%	19%	4	-2	0	0	-2
B	Basingstoke & Deane	CON	n/a	33	10	5	0	6	54	61%	19%	9%	0%	11%	4	-8	-2	0	6
	Brentwood	CON	2016	22	2	13	0	0	37	59%	5%	35%	0%	0%	3	-1	-1	0	-1
	Broxbourne	CON	2016	27	3	0	0	0	30	90%	10%	0%	0%	0%	0	0	0	0	0
	Burnley	NOC	2016	9	18	8	5	5	45	20%	40%	18%	11%	11%	3	-3	-3	3	0
B	Cambridge	LAB	n/a	0	27	12	2	1	42	0%	64%	29%	5%	2%	0	1	-3	2	0
	Cannock Chase	CON	2016	24	9	2	1	5	41	59%	22%	5%	2%	12%	9	-9	0	-1	1
	Castle Point	CON	2016	21	0	0	0	20	41	51%	0%	0%	0%	49%	-3	0	0	0	3
	Cheltenham	LD	2016	8	0	30	0	2	40	20%	0%	75%	0%	5%	2	0	-1	0	-1
	Cherwell	CON	2016	31	9	3	1	4	48	65%	19%	6%	2%	8%	-1	0	1	0	0
B	Chorley	LAB	n/a	13	29	0	0	0	42	31%	69%	0%	0%	0%	3	-1	0	0	-2
	Colchester	NOC	2016	23	11	12	2	3	51	45%	22%	24%	4%	6%	0	0	-1	1	0
	Crawley	NOC	2019	18	17	0	0	1	36	50%	47%	0%	0%	3%	1	-1	0	0	0
	Eastleigh	LD	2018	2	0	32	0	5	39	5%	0%	82%	0%	13%	0	0	0	0	0
	Elmbridge	NOC	2016	22	0	9	0	16	1	48	46%	0%	19%	0%	33%	0	0	0	0
	Epping Forest	CON	2016	36	0	4	3	15	58	62%	0%	7%	5%	26%	-1	0	1	0	0
	Exeter	LAB	2016	6	28	2	2	1	39	15%	72%	5%	5%	3%	0	-1	0	1	0
	Fareham	CON	2016	23	0	5	0	3	31	74%	0%	16%	0%	10%	1	0	0	0	-1
	Gloucester	CON	2016	26	3	10	0	0	39	67%	8%	26%	0%	0%	4	-7	3	0	0
	Gosport	CON	2016	19	1	14	0	0	34	56%	3%	41%	0%	0%	1	-2	1	0	0
	Harlow	CON	2016	20	12	0	0	0	1	33	61%	36%	0%	0%	0%	7	-7	0	0
	Hart	NOC	2016	12	0	10	0	11	33	36%	0%	30%	0%	33%	1	0	0	0	-1
	Hastings	LAB	2018	12	19	0	1	0	32	38%	59%	0%	3%	0%	4	-5	0	1	0
	Havant	CON	2016	36	1	1	0	0	38	95%	3%	3%	0%	0%	3	-1	0	0	-2
	Hyndburn	LAB	2016	12	22	0	0	1	35	34%	63%	0%	0%	3%	4	-4	0	0	0
	Ipswich	LAB	2016	15	30	3	0	0	48	31%	63%	6%	0%	0%	6	-6	0	0	0
	Lincoln	LAB	2016	10	22	1	0	0	33	30%	67%	3%	0%	0%	1	-2	1	0	0
	Maidstone	CON	2016	29	4	17	0	5	55	53%	7%	31%	0%	9%	5	0	-4	0	-1
	Mole Valley	LD	2016	12	0	22	0	7	41	29%	0%	54%	0%	17%	0	0	0	0	0
	North Hertfordshire	NOC	2016	23	15	11	0	0	49	47%	31%	22%	0%	0%	1	-1	0	0	0
	Norwich	LAB	2019	0	26	3	9	0	1	39	0%	67%	8%	23%	0	0	0	0	0
	Nuneaton & Bedworth	CON	2016	24	7	0	1	2	34	71%	21%	0%	3%	6%	10	-10	0	0	0
B	Oxford	LAB	n/a	0	34	9	3	2	48	0%	71%	19%	6%	4%	0	-3	1	1	1
B	Pendle	CON	n/a	18	10	5	0	0	33	55%	30%	15%	0%	0%	1	-1	0	0	0

		Seats last contested	Council composition (post May 2021 elections)							Share of seats (%)					Total councillors compared with when seats last contested				
Authority			CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	Vacant	Total	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH
District councils																			
Preston	LAB	2019	11	30	7	0	0		48	23%	63%	15%	0%	0%	2	0	-2	0	0
Redditch	CON	2016	25	4	0	0	0		29	86%	14%	0%	0%	0%	7	-7	0	0	0
Reigate & Banstead	CON	2019	28	0	3	7	7		45	62%	0%	7%	16%	16%	-1	0	0	1	0
Rochford	CON	2016	27	0	3	1	8		39	69%	0%	8%	3%	21%	2	0	0	-2	0
Rossendale	NOC	2016	15	18	0	0	3		36	42%	50%	0%	0%	8%	2	-2	0	0	0
Rugby	CON	2016	25	8	9	0	0		42	60%	19%	21%	0%	0%	2	-1	0	0	-1
Runnymede	CON	2019	26	1	3	0	11		41	63%	2%	7%	0%	27%	1	-1	0	-1	1
Rushmoor	CON	2016	29	9	1	0	0		39	74%	23%	3%	0%	0%	3	-2	0	0	-1
St Albans	LD	2016	23	2	30	1	2		58	40%	3%	52%	2%	3%	-1	-3	5	0	-1
Stevenage	LAB	2016	11	22	6	0	0		39	28%	56%	15%	0%	0%	4	-5	1	0	0
Stroud	NOC	2016	20	15	3	13	0		51	39%	29%	6%	25%	0%	-3	-3	1	5	0
Tamworth	CON	2016	26	3	0	0	1		30	87%	10%	0%	0%	3%	4	-2	0	0	-2
Tandridge	NOC	2016	14	0	9	0	18	1	42	33%	0%	21%	0%	43%	-1	0	-3	0	4
Three Rivers	LD	2016	11	3	23	0	2		39	28%	8%	59%	0%	5%	0	0	0	0	0
Tunbridge Wells	NOC	2016	24	5	13	0	6		48	50%	10%	27%	0%	13%	-6	1	4	0	1
Watford	LD	2016	0	10	24	0	2		36	0%	28%	67%	0%	6%	0	0	0	0	0
Welwyn Hatfield	CON	2016	28	9	11	0	0		48	58%	19%	23%	0%	0%	5	-4	-1	0	0
West Lancashire	NOC	2016	20	26	0	0	8		54	37%	48%	0%	0%	15%	1	-3	0	0	2
West Oxfordshire	CON	2016	28	8	10	1	2		49	57%	16%	20%	2%	4%	-3	0	2	1	0
Winchester	LD	2016	16	0	27	0	2		45	36%	0%	60%	0%	4%	1	0	-1	0	0
Woking	NOC	2016	13	3	12	0	2		30	43%	10%	40%	0%	7%	-2	0	3	0	-1
Worcester	CON	2016	18	11	2	4	0		35	51%	31%	6%	11%	0%	2	-4	1	1	0
Worthing	CON	2016	19	15	3	0	0		37	51%	41%	8%	0%	0%	-5	6	0	0	-1
Total district councils			1,112	606	442	59	199	4	2,422	46%	25%	18%	2%	8%	+99	-113	+3	+14	-3

		Seats last contested	Council composition (post May 2021 elections)							Share of seats (%)					Total councillors compared with when seats last contested				
Authority			CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	Vacant	Total	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH
Metropolitan district councils																			
	LAB	2016	3	49	7	0	4		63	5%	78%	11%	0%	6%	0	-1	3	0	-2
	NOC	2016	21	19	5	0	15		60	35%	32%	8%	0%	25%	4	-5	0	0	1
	LAB	2016	25	51	7	3	4		90	28%	57%	8%	3%	4%	4	-1	-1	1	-3
	LAB	2016	15	27	4	0	5		51	29%	53%	8%	0%	10%	0	-2	0	0	2
	LAB	2016	16	28	5	0	2		51	31%	55%	10%	0%	4%	2	0	-2	0	0
	LAB	2016	15	39	0	0	0		54	28%	72%	0%	0%	0%	1	-1	0	0	0
	LAB	2017	11	40	0	0	4		55	20%	73%	0%	0%	7%	4	-3	0	0	-1
	CON	2016	46	24	0	0	2		72	64%	33%	0%	0%	3%	12	-11	0	0	-1
	LAB	2016	0	52	13	0	1		66	0%	79%	20%	0%	2%	0	0	0	0	0
	NOC	2016	19	33	9	3	5		69	28%	48%	13%	4%	7%	2	-1	-1	0	0
	LAB	2016	0	34	3	5	3		45	0%	76%	7%	11%	7%	0	-3	0	2	1
	LAB	2018	24	54	8	3	10		99	24%	55%	8%	3%	10%	1	-2	0	0	1
	LAB	2016	0	70	12	4	4		90	0%	78%	13%	4%	4%	0	-3	3	0	0
	LAB	2018	0	94	1	1	0		96	0%	98%	1%	1%	0%	0	0	-1	1	0
	LAB	2018	0	52	20	0	6		78	0%	67%	26%	0%	8%	0	-2	0	0	2
	LAB	2016	9	50	0	0	0	1	60	15%	83%	0%	0%	0%	2	-1	-1	0	0
	LAB	2016	8	40	8	0	4		60	13%	67%	13%	0%	7%	4	-6	0	0	2
	LAB	2016	9	45	3	0	3		60	15%	75%	5%	0%	5%	0	0	0	0	0
B	Rotherham	n/a	20	32	3	0	4		59	34%	54%	5%	0%	7%	20	-12	3	0	-11
B	Salford	n/a	7	52	1	0	0		60	12%	87%	2%	0%	0%	-1	0	1	0	0
	Sandwell	2016	9	58	0	0	4	1	72	13%	81%	0%	0%	6%	9	-9	0	0	0
	Sefton	2016	8	48	8	0	2		66	12%	73%	12%	0%	3%	2	6	-5	0	-3
	Sheffield	NOC	1	41	29	13	0		84	1%	49%	35%	15%	0%	1	-8	3	5	-1
	Solihull	CON	30	2	3	15	1		51	59%	4%	6%	29%	2%	3	-1	-3	1	0
	South Tyneside	LAB	1	44	0	3	6		54	2%	81%	0%	6%	11%	1	-4	0	2	1
	St Helens	LAB	3	35	4	3	3		48	6%	73%	8%	6%	6%	0	-3	0	1	2
	Stockport	NOC	8	25	26	1	3		63	13%	40%	41%	2%	5%	0	0	-1	1	0
	Sunderland	LAB	18	42	12	0	3		75	24%	56%	16%	0%	4%	6	-9	4	-1	0
	Tameside	LAB	6	50	0	1	0		57	11%	88%	0%	2%	0%	1	-1	0	0	0
	Trafford	LAB	17	40	3	3	0		63	27%	63%	5%	5%	0%	-4	4	-1	1	0
	Wakefield	LAB	17	43	2	0	1		63	27%	68%	3%	0%	2%	6	-6	1	0	-1
	Walsall	CON	36	22	0	0	2		60	60%	37%	0%	0%	3%	5	-3	-2	0	0
	Wigan	LAB	8	57	0	0	10		75	11%	76%	0%	0%	13%	0	0	0	0	0
	Wirral	NOC	23	30	6	5	2		66	35%	45%	9%	8%	3%	1	-4	0	3	0
	Wolverhampton	LAB	15	44	0	0	1		60	25%	73%	0%	0%	2%	5	-5	0	0	0
Total metropolitan district councils			448	1,466	202	63	114	2	2,295	20%	64%	9%	3%	5%	+91	-97	0	+17	-11

		Seats last contested	Council composition (post May 2021 elections)							Share of seats (%)					Total councillors compared with when seats last contested					
Authority			CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	Vacant	Total	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	CON	LAB	LD	GRN	OTH	
Unitary authorities																				
	Blackburn with Darwen	LAB	2018	14	35	1	0	1	51	27%	69%	2%	0%	2%	1	0	-1	0	0	
	Bristol	NOC	2016	14	24	8	24	0	70	20%	34%	11%	34%	0%	0	-13	0	13	0	
B	Buckinghamshire	CON	n/a	113	4	15	1	14	147	77%	3%	10%	1%	10%	-10	1	3	1	5	
B	Cornwall	CON	2017	47	5	13	1	21	87	54%	6%	15%	1%	24%	19	2	-16	1	-6	
	Derby	NOC	2016	21	13	8	0	9	51	41%	25%	16%	0%	18%	2	-3	0	0	1	
	Durham	NOC	2017	24	53	17	1	31	126	19%	42%	13%	1%	25%	14	-21	3	1	3	
B	Halton	LAB	n/a	2	48	3	1	0	54	4%	89%	6%	2%	0%	-1	0	0	1	0	
B	Hartlepool	NOC	n/a	13	11	0	0	12	36	36%	31%	0%	0%	33%	10	-3	0	0	-7	
B	Isle of Wight	NOC	2017	18	1	1	2	17	39	46%	3%	3%	5%	44%	-5	0	-1	1	5	
	Kingston-upon-Hull	LAB	2018	1	30	26	0	0	57	2%	53%	46%	0%	0%	-1	-1	2	0	0	
	Milton Keynes	NOC	2016	24	19	13	0	1	57	42%	33%	23%	0%	2%	6	-4	-2	0	0	
	North East Lincolnshire	CON	2016	31	8	3	0	0	42	74%	19%	7%	0%	0%	8	-7	-1	0	0	
B	North Northamptonshire	CON	n/a	60	14	0	3	1	78	77%	18%	0%	4%	1%	0	-1	-3	3	1	
	Northumberland	CON	2017	34	21	3	2	7	67	51%	31%	4%	3%	10%	1	-3	0	2	0	
	Peterborough	NOC	2016	29	15	8	3	5	60	48%	25%	13%	5%	8%	1	1	-2	1	-1	
	Plymouth	NOC	2016	25	24	0	0	8	57	44%	42%	0%	0%	14%	6	-6	0	0	0	
	Portsmouth	NOC	2016	16	7	15	0	4	42	38%	17%	36%	0%	10%	1	0	-2	0	1	
	Reading	LAB	2016	9	30	2	5	0	46	20%	65%	4%	11%	0%	-1	0	0	1	0	
	Shropshire	CON	2017	43	9	14	4	4	74	58%	12%	19%	5%	5%	-6	1	2	3	0	
	Slough	LAB	2016	5	34	0	0	3	42	12%	81%	0%	0%	7%	0	-1	0	0	1	
	Southampton	CON	2016	25	23	0	0	0	48	52%	48%	0%	0%	0%	7	-6	0	0	-1	
	Southend-on-Sea	NOC	2016	23	13	5	0	10	51	45%	25%	10%	0%	20%	3	1	0	0	-4	
	Swindon	CON	2016	36	20	0	0	1	57	63%	35%	0%	0%	2%	6	-4	-2	0	0	
	Thurrock	CON	2016	29	16	0	0	4	49	59%	33%	0%	0%	8%	6	0	0	0	-6	
	Warrington	LAB	2016	11	36	8	0	3	58	19%	62%	14%	0%	5%	9	-9	-3	0	3	
B	West Northamptonshire	CON	n/a	66	20	5	0	2	93	71%	22%	5%	0%	2%	-3	-1	2	0	2	
B	Wiltshire	CON	2017	61	3	27	0	7	98	62%	3%	28%	0%	7%	-7	1	6	0	0	
	Wokingham	CON	2016	31	3	18	0	2	54	57%	6%	33%	0%	4%	-2	-1	3	0	0	
Total unitary authorities				825	539	213	47	167	0	1,791	46%	30%	12%	3%	9%	+64	-77	-12	+28	-3

Source: BBC

Notes:

B indicates that a boundary change has occurred in the local authority since the last scheduled elections.

English council control immediately after local elections

	2005	2006	2007	2008	2009	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2021
London boroughs																
CON	8	14	14	14	14	11	11	11	11	9	9	9	9	7	7	7
LAB	15	7	7	7	7	17	17	17	17	20	20	21	21	21	21	21
LD	3	3	3	3	3	2	2	2	2	1	1	1	1	3	3	3
OTH	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
NOC	6	8	8	8	8	2	2	2	2	2	2	1	1	1	1	1
Counties																
CON	23	23	23	23	26	26	26	26	16	16	16	16	24	24	23	21
LAB	6	6	6	5	0	0	0	0	2	2	2	1	0	0	0	0
LD	3	3	3	3	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
OTH	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
NOC	2	2	2	3	1	1	1	1	9	9	9	10	3	3	3	3
Metropolitan boroughs																
CON	4	5	4	6	6	3	3	2	2	2	2	2	2	1	2	3
LAB	16	15	13	12	12	16	24	29	29	30	30	29	29	30	30	28
LD	3	3	4	4	5	2	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
OTH	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
NOC	13	13	15	14	13	15	9	5	5	4	4	5	5	5	4	5
Shire districts																
CON	109	114	145	151	137	135	136	131	131	119	146	143	143	143	95	86
LAB	22	18	13	12	5	7	19	31	32	33	30	30	29	27	25	17
LD	17	19	18	18	15	18	11	9	9	9	5	6	7	8	19	18
OTH	7	5	5	5	4	4	1	1	1	1	2	1	2	1	5	5
NOC	83	82	57	52	40	37	34	29	28	39	18	21	20	22	48	55
Unitary authorities																
CON	11	12	18	19	24	24	23	20	20	18	19	21	22	23	16	22
LAB	12	8	9	8	9	10	17	23	23	21	18	19	20	20	15	11
LD	5	4	1	1	3	3	1	1	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	1
OTH	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
NOC	18	22	18	18	19	18	14	11	11	16	18	15	13	12	23	24

Source: Rallings and Thrasher, Local Elections Handbooks 2005-2016 and Local Government Chronicle articles

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